

utes, hours, or days—or simply at startup or shutdown. When the backup process starts, the software checks for modified or deleted files, and appropriately updates the destination folder. There are various options for the type of backup. Simple Copy just dumps modified files from the source directory to the destination directory. Then there is Exact Copy, which relocates the modified files and also deletes the source files; Move moves the files from source to destination. Options such as Compress and Exact Compress are provided; these provide a single zip file as output.

The Synchronize option synchronises the files between the source and destination locations: if you have a file called my.doc in the source location, Second Copy creates a copy in the destination folder. If you now modify the file in the destination folder, Second Copy automatically copies the file to the source folder, thus maintaining the latest version of the file.

Second Copy is best suited for small-office users, with a local network connecting individual machines to a dedicated file server.

- + Provides a variety of copy types
- Backup data is not secured; no support for backup on removable media

Second Copy 2000	
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶
Features	▶▶▶▶▶
Ease of use	▶▶▶▶▶
Overall	▶▶▶▶▶

WinBackup

Winning backup

WinBackup provides a highly secure environment for both the application and the backups. The backup is secured in one of two ways—encryption of 128 or 256-bit AESs, and user-supplied passwords. You can provide a password for the application as well, to deter hackers. Like a couple of other products (Second Copy and Save-N-Sync), it does not keep the backup files in open format, thus preventing any accidental corruption or deletion.



'Schedule Backup' lets you schedule the frequency at which backups are done

You can also save the resulting image file in compressed form, by activating the 'Compress data to save space' option in the Backup Settings. One good feature is that whenever you select a folder, the size of the final compressed file is immediately displayed. This feature helps decide where to place

Computer Forensics

Data recovery and presentation of legal evidence has lead to a complete computer forensics industry. Of all the factors involved, data recovery and analysis is probably the most important. These forensic experts don't just use the professional recovery software available in the market—they usually use their own customised tools. Even then, all recovery cannot be done using software; a lot of it depends on the techniques used by the experts. Each recovery case is unique in some way, and has to be dealt with differently. But what really matters in the end is the amount and quality of data recovered, and the way it is presented to the legal authorities.

the resulting file. Like other software, WinBackup has a scheduler, and also in-built support for data backup directly onto CD or DVD. It also supports spanning of backup files across more than one CD or DVD. If the event that the file is too small for an entire disk, it supports multi-session CDs or DVDs, which efficiently utilises a single medium to its full capacity. All in all, security, coupled with support to create backups directly on CD and DVD, as well as performance, makes WinBackup the clear winner.

- + Security; spanning across media
- Backed-up data is not secured by default

WinBackup	
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶
Features	▶▶▶▶▶
Ease of use	▶▶▶▶▶
Overall	▶▶▶▶▶

Save-N-Sync v3.0

Sync your data

Save-N-Sync is a data synchronising tool. As in Second Copy, you can create more than one source and destination pairs. Data is then copied between the pair of locations. The synchronisation can be one-way or two-way at the same time. By one-way, we mean all the modified files from source are copied to destination, while two-way means the latest file, be it at source or destination, is updated to the other place. For example, if the version of 'my.doc' at source is the latest, it is copied to the destination folder; and if the file at destination is newer then it is copied to the source folder.



Save-N-Sync v3.0 lets you specify the source and destination paths as well as the type of synchronisation needed

Synchronisation can be scheduled with the in-built scheduler. The software took nearly 50 per cent longer than any other software, to copy the test data. While copying an entire drive, it didn't copy files from the System Volume Information folder. So, if you run Windows XP, there's a possibility that XP's System Restore function may not work after backing up the entire disk.

The unique Variable Path Selection feature inserts variables in the source or destination path fields—say you want to back up data on a particular day of the week, you can specify 'e:\back-up\%day%\1' as the target path. Whenever SNS starts, it replaces '%day%' with the day of the week. You can even use the date, username, etc., as variables. An important feature is extensive support for command line arguments. This is useful for system administrators, who may want to configure logon scripts and batch files.

SNS does lag a bit on performance, but its unique features make it stand out from the others.

- + Variable path selection, command line support
- No compression, no scheduling, no support for backup on removable media

Save-N-Sync v3.0	
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶
Features	▶▶▶▶▶
Ease of use	▶▶▶▶▶
Overall	▶▶▶▶▶